

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: JOHN BROWN UNIVERSITY

TRADITIONAL

On-Site Review: April 22–24, 2025

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
MEETS	APPROACHING	APPROACHING
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	John Brown University
LOCATION	Siloam Springs, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Educator preparation program, literacy
PATHWAY	Traditional
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	April 22-24, 2025

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 9 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	Meets
Concepts of print instruction	Meets
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	Approaching
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	Meets
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	Meets
Fluency instruction	Exceeds
Vocabulary instruction	Meets
Text comprehension instruction	Meets
Writing instruction	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers identified the coursework's alignment with the Arkansas SOR framework as a key strength, noting that courses give candidates a foundation in phonemic awareness, decoding, encoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, framed using Scarborough's Rope, the Four-Part Processing Model, and Ehri's Phases of Word Reading Development. Fluency instruction was the highest-rated criterion in this area. Oral language instruction and writing instruction were rated Approaching.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Strengthen integration of oral language across coursework and deepen understanding, including explicit and consistent treatment of all six language structures. • Expand applied learning through practice-based experiences, including structured peer teaching, faculty modeling, and supervised fieldwork. • Strengthen writing instruction.	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 11 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	Approaching
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	Approaching
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	Exceeds
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Approaching
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Meets
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Approaching
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Approaching
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Approaching
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Approaching
Quality of written and oral feedback	Approaching
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	Meets
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Of the eleven criteria in this area, eight were rated Approaching, two were rated Meets, and one was rated Exceeds. Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice was the highest-rated criterion. The ratings concentrate on placement selection, mentor capacity, and the quality of observation and feedback.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Formalize a structure for clinical placement, with clear criteria for selecting sites in Blocks I and II and Internship. • Conduct training on observation and feedback practices for faculty, university supervisors, and mentor teachers. • Monitor the impact of observation and feedback practices.	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 7 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Approaching
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Approaching
Quality of monitoring	Approaching
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Approaching
Quality improvement planning	Approaching
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Approaching
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
All seven criteria in this area were rated Approaching. Reviewers found that the program collects data and reviews it, but that the systems are fragmented and the review process remains largely compliance-oriented and operational in focus.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Develop a system for data collection and monitoring, including a data management platform. • Enhance data collection, prioritizing the Aspiring TESS rubric from field experiences to internship. • Develop a comprehensive monitoring system covering coursework, faculty teaching, and clinical components.	

Sources: TPI-US Written Report & Recommendations, John Brown University, April 22-24, 2025, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024). Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework. Ratings are transcribed from the review report's own rating tables. Code Ann. 6-17-429.